

Best Sales Performance Management Software? Here Are 16 Options, Sorted by Who They Actually Fit

By Doug Erb, Founder, Lanshore

Disclosure first. Lanshore is a consulting firm. We implement and support several of the platforms in this article, we build custom compensation solutions on top of CRM and ERP data, and we have partner relationships in this market, including a listed partnership with Akeron, whose Vulki platform appears below. That means we are not neutral either. What we are is on the hook after go-live, which is a different vantage point from a vendor writing about itself. Nothing in this article was paid for and no vendor reviewed it.

Three lists, three number ones

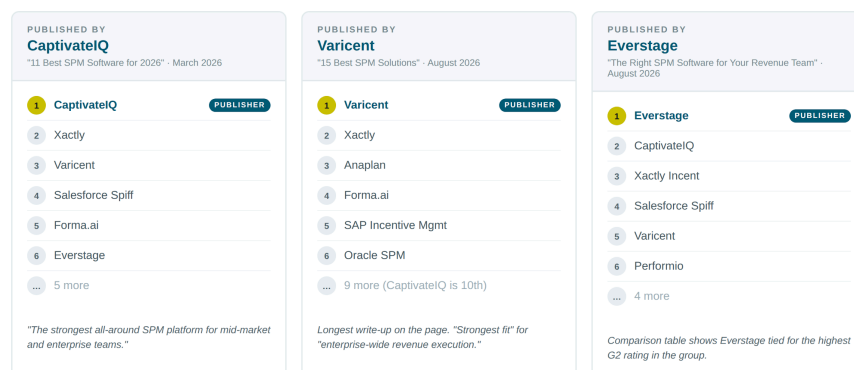
Last month I read three "best sales performance management software" articles back to back.

CaptivateIQ's list of 11 puts CaptivateIQ first and calls it "the strongest all-around SPM platform for mid-market and enterprise teams." Varicent's list of 15 opens its enterprise tier with Varicent and gives it the longest write-up on the page. Everstage's list of 10 leads with Everstage, and the comparison table shows Everstage tied for the highest G2 score in the group.

FIGURE 1

Three "best SPM software" lists, three number ones

Same category, same month, same search results page. The only thing that changes is who published the article.



Same pattern every time: the publisher goes first or leads its tier, gets the longest write-up on the page, and ends with a demo button. Position and length are the ranking. The score table is decoration.

Figure 1. Three "best SPM software" lists, three number ones.

None of those articles is lying. Each one is a sales page with a table of contents. The problem is that a comp leader searching for "best sales performance management software" gets three of these on page one, reads them as research, and walks into a selection with a shortlist someone else wrote.

I started in this business in 2000, architecting commission systems on Callidus TrueComp and on Trilogy's DMS, a product most people reading this have never heard of because Trilogy stopped being a factor in this market two decades ago. The plans I built on it are still being paid, on their third platform. Since then I have personally architected implementations on Varicent, Xactly, CaptivateIQ, Performio and SAP Commissions, and rescued more spreadsheet comp processes than I want to admit.

That matters for this article in one specific way. I do not evaluate these products from the demo. I evaluate them from the data model, because that is where they succeed or fail after go-live. This is the list I would hand a client. Sixteen options, fourteen you buy and two you build. It does not rank anything. It tells you who each option is built for, how it is actually built underneath, what it does well, where it hurts, and what the evidence behind the marketing actually says.

How a "best SPM software" list gets made

A few mechanics worth knowing before you read any of them, including this one.

The vendor goes first, and gets the most words. In all three articles above, the publishing vendor is either listed first or leads its tier, and gets the longest write-up on the page. Position and length are the ranking. The numbers in the table are decoration.

G2 has two different categories and vendors quote whichever one flatters them. G2 runs a "Sales Compensation" category, where the incentive compensation platforms live, and a separate "Sales Performance Management" category, which as of September 2026 is dominated by CRMs like HubSpot Sales Hub, Pipedrive and monday CRM. A vendor can be a Leader on one grid and absent from the other. When an article says "G2 Leader in SPM," ask which grid.

A G2 score is half satisfaction and half size. G2 publishes its method. The G2 Score is the average of two components, Satisfaction and Market Presence. Market Presence is built from weighted review count, employee counts pulled from ZoomInfo and LinkedIn, revenue estimates, Moz domain authority, search volume and web traffic. A well-funded vendor with a big marketing team moves up the grid before a single customer says anything.

FIGURE 2

What actually goes into a G2 Grid position

G2 publishes its method. The G2 Score is the average of two components, and only one of them is about what customers think.



Lanshore · Sources: documentation.g2.com/docs/research-scoring-methodologies, learn.g2.com/algorithm-update-what-to-know, legal.g2.com/community-guidelines

lanshore.com

Figure 2. What actually goes into a G2 Grid position.

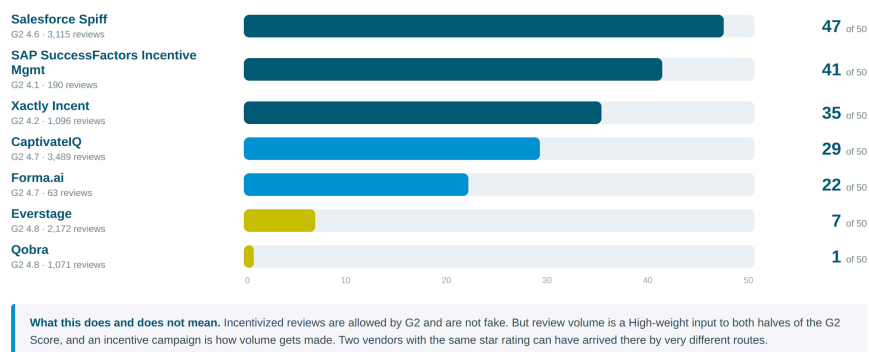
Reviews can be paid for, up to \$100 each. G2's community guidelines allow incentives up to \$100 per review and require those reviews to be tagged "Incentivized." G2 says paying for a profile does not buy ranking, and I take them at their word on the algorithm. But review volume is a High-weight input, and review volume is exactly what an incentive campaign produces. On September 21, 2026 I opened the G2 review page for each vendor below and counted the incentivized tags on the 50 reviews G2 shows first. The spread is wide:

Vendor	G2 rating	Total reviews	Incentivized, of first 50 shown
Salesforce Spiff	4.6	3,115	47
SAP SuccessFactors Incentive Management	4.1	190	41
Xactly Incent	4.2	1,096	35
CaptivateIQ	4.7	3,489	29
Forma.ai	4.7	63	22
Everstage	4.8	2,172	7
Qobra	4.8	1,071	1

FIGURE 3

Incentivized tags in the first 50 G2 reviews shown, by vendor

Counted by hand on September 21, 2026 from each product's public G2 review page. G2 labels a review "Incentivized" when the reviewer was offered a nominal gift card or donation, capped at \$100.



Lanshore · Source: g2.com product review pages, first 50 reviews displayed, September 21, 2026; legal.g2.com/community-guidelines

lanshore.com

Figure 3. Incentivized tags in the first 50 G2 reviews shown, by vendor, September 21, 2026.

That is not fraud. It is the mechanism working as designed, and it means the star ratings above are not measuring the same thing from one vendor to the next. Read them with that in mind.

Gartner tells you not to do what the press releases imply. Four vendors put out releases in July 2026 announcing Leader placement in the 2026 Gartner Magic Quadrant for SPM. Every one of those releases carries Gartner's own disclaimer: Gartner "does not advise technology users to select only those vendors with the highest ratings or other designation." Thirteen vendors were evaluated. Per the report (Gartner, Magic Quadrant for Sales Performance Management, G00841323, July 6, 2026), Anaplan, Xactly, Varicent and CaptivateIQ are Leaders; Everstage and Performio are Challengers; Salesforce, Forma.ai and SAP are Visionaries; Pigment, Fullcast, Oracle and Akeron are Niche Players. Those are positions on two axes Gartner defines, Ability to Execute and Completeness of Vision, weighted toward product, customer experience, sales strategy and offering strategy. Neither axis is "fit for a 200-rep distributor on Dynamics." The nine vendors that did not issue a Leader press release are not worse for your situation. They are less visible.

Nobody publishes the implementation timeline. Of the fourteen vendors below, the only ones stating a go-live window on their own site are Everstage (4 to 6 weeks), QuotaPath (45 to 90 days by tier), Performio (4 to 8 weeks with its new implementation agents) and Salesforce Spiff (a 4 to 6 week "Jumpstart" for Salesforce-only deployments). Every enterprise platform is silent, and the third-party estimates run three to nine months. My own enterprise programs on Varicent, Xactly and SAP Commissions have run six to twelve months from kickoff to first live payout, and the platform was never the reason. Plan complexity was: dozens of variants, legacy exceptions nobody would kill, and a parallel run that had to reconcile to the penny before Finance would sign. That silence on the vendor sites is the most important data point in the market.

What I look at instead

When a client asks which platform to buy, the answer depends on five things, and none of them is a star rating.

1. **Payee count and plan count.** Under 50 payees on two or three plans is a different product category from 5,000 payees on 200 plan variants.
2. **Plan complexity.** Flat rate plans versus multi-tier accelerators, splits, overlays, clawbacks, draws, MBOs and mid-period changes.
3. **Systems landscape.** Salesforce shop, SAP shop, Oracle shop, HubSpot shop, or a mix with a data warehouse in the middle.
4. **Who administers it.** A RevOps analyst who wants no-code self-service, or a comp team with a dedicated admin and an SI on retainer.
5. **What Finance needs.** ASC 606 commission capitalization, SOX controls, audit trail per payee per contract, multi-currency, multi-entity.

Score each option against those five and the "best" platform for a 40-rep SaaS company and the best platform for a 3,000-producer insurance carrier are never the same product, no matter what the grid says.

How these engines are actually built, and why it matters more than the demo

Every vendor demo shows a plan being configured in an afternoon. What the demo cannot show is what happens in month fourteen when the hierarchy changes retroactively and the admin who built it has left. That outcome is decided by the engine's architecture, and there are really three families.

FIGURE 4

The three ways a commission engine is built

What the demo cannot show is month fourteen, when the hierarchy changes retroactively and the admin who built it has left. That outcome is decided by architecture, and by who can read the logic.

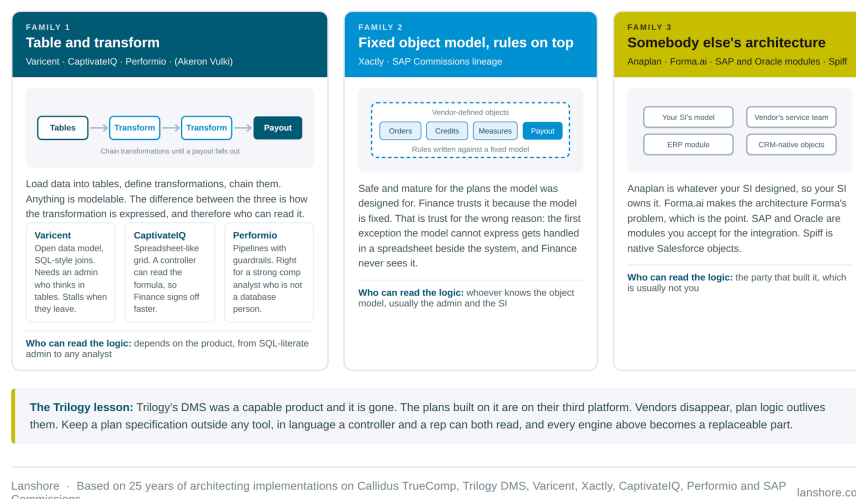


Figure 4. The three ways a commission engine is built, and who can read the logic in each.

Table-and-transform engines: Varicent, CaptivateIQ, Performio. These three are more alike than their marketing admits. You load data into tables, define transformations, and chain the transformations until a payout falls out the end. The difference is how the transformations are expressed and therefore who can read them.

Varicent is the purest version. It is an open data model where you build by linking tables with SQL-style joins. That is why anything is modelable in it: I have built insurance producer hierarchies with six levels of override and mid-month effective dates that no other packaged product would express. It is also why it needs an administrator who thinks in tables and joins. When that person leaves, and they do, the client typically runs for months without making a change until something breaks and they call an SI. The slow calculation runs reviewers complain about are usually a bad join, not the engine.

CaptivateIQ expresses the same idea in a spreadsheet-like grid. The consequence is that a RevOps analyst can read the formula, and more importantly a Finance controller can read it too. In my experience that legibility is why Finance signs off on CaptivateIQ faster than on anything else in this list. It runs out at the top end, when the grid gets so wide that nobody can hold it in their head, which is roughly where the enterprise platforms start.

Performio is the middle ground: a pipeline model like Varicent, with more guardrails and less rope. I would put a comp analyst who is comfortable with data but not with SQL on it.

Fixed object model with rules on top: Xactly, and the SAP Commissions lineage. Xactly gives you a defined set of objects (orders, credits, measurements, incentives, deposits) and you write rules against them. Finance tends to trust it because the model is fixed and the vendor is

mature. That is trust for the wrong reason. The model is safe right up until you need an exception it cannot express, and every enterprise plan has one. What I have watched happen, more than once, is the analyst handling the exception in a spreadsheet next to the system, applying the adjustment on the way to payroll, and Finance never seeing it. The system of record is accurate for everything except the thing that caused the dispute.

Everything else. Anaplan is a planning model you build ICM inside, so the architecture is whatever your SI designed. Forma.ai is a managed service where the architecture is Forma's problem, which is the point. SAP and Oracle are ERP modules whose architecture you accept because the integration story is why you bought them. Spiff is native Salesforce objects. Akeron's Vulki sits closest to the table-and-transform family with its DataFlow layer.

The lesson I took from Trilogy is the one that governs all of this. Trilogy's DMS was a capable product, and it is gone. The plans I built on it were re-implemented on TrueComp, and some of those have since moved again. Vendors disappear. Plan logic outlives them. Which means the single most valuable artifact in your comp program is a plan specification that lives outside any tool, in language a controller and a rep can both read, from which any of these engines can be built. If you cannot produce that document today, that is the first project, before the selection.

The 16 options

Grouped by the customer they were built for. G2 ratings and review counts are as of September 21, 2026 and will drift. Analyst positions are from the July 2026 Gartner Magic Quadrant for SPM and the Q1 2025 Forrester Wave for SPM Solutions for Incentive Compensation.

Enterprise platforms: 1,000 to 50,000 payees, complex plans, SI-led, six to twelve months in my experience

1. Varicent

What it is: The former IBM ICM product, spun out in 2020, now backed by Great Hill, Spectrum and Warburg Pincus. A Leader in the 2026 Gartner MQ for the eighth consecutive time and a Leader in the 2025 Forrester Wave. Partner-led implementations through Deloitte, ZS, Accenture, KPMG and others (Lanshore).

Fits: Financial services, insurance and telecom with large producer populations, hierarchies that change monthly, and a comp team that expects to own the model. Named customers include CNA, CDW, Fiserv and Zions.

Pros: The deepest calculation and data engine in the market, and the only one where I have never hit a plan structure I could not model. Territory and quota planning in the same platform. Strongest AI roadmap of the enterprise group per Forrester.

Cons: G2 4.5 on 610 reviews, with recurring complaints about slow calculation runs as complexity grows and multi-week support tickets. The open data model is the strength and the cost: you need an administrator who thinks in SQL, and when that person leaves the program stalls until an SI is re-engaged. Budget for that person or that retainer from day one. Third-party estimates put deployments at three to six months; mine have run longer. No published pricing.

2. Xactly Incent

What it is: The original SaaS ICM vendor, owned by Vista Equity since 2017. Gartner MQ Leader 2026. Three tiers (Core, Plus, Ultimate), quote only. Shipped a "Fleet of Agents" and an MCP server in May 2026, including a dispute management agent on the ServiceNow store.

Fits: Upper mid-market and enterprise SaaS, med device and manufacturing with a comp team that wants a mature product and a large partner ecosystem. Customers include LinkedIn, Zoom, Toast and Illumina.

Pros: Broad functionality, benchmarking data no one else has, and among the most shipped agentic features of any vendor as of this writing.

Cons: G2 4.2 on 1,096 reviews, the lowest of the four MQ Leaders, with 35 of the first 50 shown incentivized. The top complaints are UI navigation, slow loading and learning curve. The deeper issue is architectural: a fixed object model handles the plans it was designed for and pushes the exceptions into spreadsheets beside the system, where Finance cannot see them. Ask every Xactly reference how they handle the plan the model cannot express. Third-party contract data shows median deals around \$80K per year with 3 to 7 percent annual escalators and implementation quoted separately.

3. SAP SuccessFactors Incentive Management (formerly SAP Commissions, formerly CallidusCloud)

What it is: The Callidus TrueComp lineage, acquired by SAP in 2018 for roughly \$2.4B and renamed twice since. A Visionary in the 2026 Gartner MQ. Partner-led implementations.

Fits: Companies already standardized on SAP S/4HANA or SuccessFactors that want commissions inside the SAP support and licensing umbrella. Retail, manufacturing, energy, med device.

Pros: The calculation engine has been paying enterprise commissions for over two decades and it does not break at volume. Joule copilot now gives payees conversational access to their statements.

Cons: G2 4.1 on 190 reviews, the lowest in this list, and 41 of the first 50 reviews shown carried the incentivized tag when I looked. The consistent complaint is that plan changes and reports "often require help from experts." Third-party estimates run six to nine months. BTP and Integration Suite are licensed separately, which surprises buyers.

Vertical note: If you are an SAP shop, put it on the shortlist. If you are not, there is no reason to.

4. Oracle Sales Performance Management (Fusion Incentive Compensation)

What it is: Oracle's organic Fusion module. A Niche Player in the 2026 MQ. Oracle runs it internally for 25,000-plus payees.

Fits: Oracle Fusion ERP and HCM customers. Same logic as SAP: the integration and licensing story is the reason to buy.

Pros: Single platform with Oracle finance and HR. New payee-facing "Incentive Compensation Coach and Advisor" agent in the 26B release.

Cons: G2 4.0 on 112 reviews. Gartner Peer Insights reviewers cite integration with non-Oracle apps, performance and user experience. G2's aggregate shows five-month implementations and a 17-month payback.

5. Anaplan

What it is: A connected planning platform, taken private by Thoma Bravo in 2022 for roughly \$10.4B, that partners build ICM models on. Gartner MQ Leader 2026, claiming the highest Ability to Execute.

Fits: Enterprises that already run FP&A, territory and quota planning on Anaplan and want commissions in the same model. Pharma and financial services. Alkem Labs runs 10,000 field agents on it.

Pros: Unmatched for scenario modeling and plan design analysis. One data model from quota to payout.

Cons: There is no packaged ICM engine. Your SI builds it, which means your SI owns it. G2 reviewers describe pricing that "puts it out of reach for all but the largest companies" and slow calculations on large data. Third-party data shows implementation at 75 to 150 percent of first-year subscription.

6. beqom

What it is: A Swiss total-compensation platform (merit, bonus, long-term incentives and sales commissions) backed by a \$300M Sumeru investment. Not in the 2026 Gartner SPM MQ.

Fits: Global 5000 companies that want one system for every variable pay type across 50 countries. Customers include Mercedes-Benz, PepsiCo, DHL and Allianz.

Pros: Handles regulatory and total-rewards complexity that pure sales comp tools ignore.

Cons: G2 4.3 on only 27 reviews. Reviewers call the flexibility "a double-edged sword" and cite long implementations. If your problem is sales commissions and nothing else, this is more platform than you need.

7. Forma.ai

What it is: A Toronto vendor that sells the platform bundled with a managed service. A Visionary in the 2026 MQ. Enterprise only, six-figure annual engagements.

Fits: Enterprises that want to outsource comp operations rather than staff them. Autodesk, Stryker, WEX and B. Braun are named customers.

Pros: Reviewers describe the service team as "a true extension of our team." Plans launch fast because Forma's people build them.

Cons: G2 4.7 on only 63 reviews, 22 of the first 50 shown incentivized when I looked. The trade-off is control: reviewers cite "restricted" admin self-service and CSV-only exports. You are buying a service relationship, and you should evaluate it as one.

8. Akeron (Vulki by Akeron)

What it is: A Lucca, Italy vendor run by the founders of Tagetik, backed by White Bridge Investments, with offices in New York, London and Paris and 220 staff as of mid-2024. Vulki covers sales and non-sales incentive compensation, territory and quota planning, disputes and a data integration layer called DataFlow. A Niche Player in its first 2026 Gartner MQ appearance. Launched Akyba, an AI agent center with a bring-your-own-LLM design, in April 2026.

Fits: Mid-market and enterprise companies in consumer goods, retail, luxury, financial services and sports, especially with European operations or a Microsoft Dynamics and Azure standard. Customers include Haier Europe, Lavazza, Decathlon, Juventus, Printemps and OptimizeRx in the US.

Pros: One of the few platforms that treats non-sales variable pay as a first-class use case. Sold through the Microsoft Marketplace with Lanshore, Accenture and Huron as delivery partners in North America. Gartner Peer Insights 4.9 on 25 ratings.

Cons: Almost no independent review base outside Gartner Peer Insights: G2 shows no reviews and Capterra shows four, all vendor-referred. US presence dates from 2024 and the reference base is heavily European. No published pricing or implementation timelines. Akyba is in an early-adopter "Pioneer Program." And, as disclosed above, Lanshore is a listed Akeron partner, so weigh my read accordingly.

Vertical note: If you are a CPG or retail company with European entities and a Microsoft stack, it belongs on the shortlist. If you are a US SaaS company, it probably does not yet.

Mid-market platforms: 50 to 2,000 payees, RevOps-administered, weeks not months

9. CaptivateIQ

What it is: The no-code ICM platform that put the mid-market on notice. Series C at a \$1.25B valuation in 2022. Gartner MQ Leader 2026 and Forrester Leader 2025. Agents in limited beta since May 2026.

Fits: SaaS and tech from 50 to a few thousand payees where RevOps wants to own plan changes without a consultant. Expanding into financial services and med device (Boston Scientific, Stifel, Affirm, Netflix).

Pros: G2 4.7 on 3,489 reviews, the largest review base in the category. Reviewers praise ease of use and transparency. The spreadsheet-like SmartGrid model means an analyst can read the logic, and so can a controller, which in my experience is why Finance signs off on it faster than on any other platform here.

Cons: Reviewers call reporting "cumbersome" and note slow refreshes at month end. TrustRadius complaints include no mobile app and test environments that do not match production. Per-seat pricing plus a setup fee, with ASC 606 as an add-on. Twenty nine of the first 50 reviews shown carried the incentivized tag when I looked, which does not invalidate them but does explain some of the volume.

10. Performio

What it is: A 2006 Australian vendor now headquartered in Irvine with \$75M from JMI. A Challenger in the 2026 MQ, Forrester Strong Performer 2025. Launched an AI Admin Assistant and MCP server in October 2025 and AI implementation agents in June 2026.

Fits: "100 reps to thousands" by its own positioning. Mid-market through lower enterprise across SaaS, logistics and life sciences (Uber Freight, Veeva, AstraZeneca).

Pros: Balanced product with a real calculation engine at a mid-market price. Same table-and-transform family as Varicent, with guardrails instead of open SQL, which makes it the right engine for a strong comp analyst who is not a database person. Claims 20,000-plus payees per cycle at the top end. Third-party median contract around \$50K per year.

Cons: G2 4.4 on 1,072 reviews. Complaints center on slow updates, slow loading and data bugs. Eighty percent of its customers came off spreadsheets, which tells you where the product is optimized.

11. Everstage

What it is: A Series B vendor (\$45M total, Eight Roads) with US headquarters and Indian engineering. Gartner Challenger 2026, Forrester Strong Performer 2025. Shipped "Agent Core" with four ICM agents in August 2025.

Fits: 20 to 2,000 payees. SaaS, fintech and services. Wiley, Trimble, Paychex and Postman are customers.

Pros: G2 4.8 on 2,172 reviews, the highest rating in this list among vendors with over 1,000 reviews. Publishes a 4 to 6 week go-live window, which no enterprise vendor does. Only 7 of the first 50 reviews shown were incentivized when I looked, which is worth noting given the rating.

Cons: Reviewers cite learning curve, data sync delays and difficulty getting to detail. Per-payee pricing with onboarding fee and ASC 606 as an add-on. The enterprise reference base is thinner than the rating implies.

12. Salesforce Spiff

What it is: Spiff, acquired by Salesforce in early 2024 and relaunched inside Sales Cloud. A Visionary in the 2026 MQ. Published pricing at \$75 per user per month, with non-Salesforce connectors at \$250 per connector per month.

Fits: Salesforce-standardized companies from mid-market up who want comp in the same admin console as CRM. Salesforce runs 30,000 sellers on it.

Pros: Native to Salesforce data and permissions. Published pricing. A 4 to 6 week Jumpstart for Salesforce-only deployments.

Cons: G2 4.6 on 3,115 reviews, but 47 of the first 50 shown carried the incentivized tag when I looked. Complaints: learning curve, setup complexity, cost. The connector fee adds up fast if billing and HRIS live outside Salesforce. Agentforce integration was described in August 2026 but the December 2025 release notes shipped no agent. Third parties report support quality dropped after the acquisition, which I cannot confirm from a primary source.

Growth-stage platforms: 10 to 200 payees, self-serve, published pricing

13. QuotaPath

What it is: A Series B vendor (\$41M, Tribe Capital) with fully published pricing: Growth at \$35 per user per month plus a \$525 monthly platform fee, Premium at \$50 plus \$800. Not in the Gartner MQ.

Fits: 10 to 100 reps at SaaS and services companies. Zapier, Augury and Rootly.

Pros: G2 4.8 on 384 reviews. You can read the price, start a trial and go live in 45 to 90 days by tier. Launched "Atlas," an AI plan design assistant, in June 2026.

Cons: One enterprise reviewer on G2. Complex plans and slow CRM sync are the recurring complaints, and they are the ones that matter as you grow.

14. Qobra

What it is: A Paris vendor with a UK office and a US office opened September 2026. Series A (\$10.5M, Singular). Not in the Gartner MQ.

Fits: European mid-market and US companies with European teams. 350-plus customers, 30,000 users. GoCardless, ElevenLabs, Contentsquare.

Pros: G2 4.8 on 1,071 reviews with one incentivized tag in the first 50 shown, which is rare in this category. Capterra lists pricing from \$39 per user per month.

Cons: Complaints about data update delays, limited customization and calculation confusion. US support and reference depth are unproven as of this writing.

Build options

15. Spreadsheets

What it is: Excel or Google Sheets, usually with a SQL extract and a very tired analyst.

Fits: Under 20 payees, one or two flat plans, no ASC 606 capitalization, and a Finance leader who is willing to personally own the file. It is how most companies start and it is not automatically wrong.

Pros: Zero license cost. Infinite flexibility. Every comp person alive can read it.

Cons: Panko's field audits at the University of Hawaii found errors in 94 percent of 88 audited operational spreadsheets, with cell error rates between 0.4 and 6.9 percent. A 2026 UserEvidence survey commissioned by Everstage found 60 percent of mid-market SaaS companies still run commissions on homegrown spreadsheets and that the commission cycle consumes 25 to 40 percent of senior RevOps and Finance time. Under ASC 606 and ASC 340-40, capitalized commissions have to be traceable per payee per contract with an amortization schedule, and a spreadsheet cannot show an auditor who changed what. The moment you have splits, clawbacks or a second currency, the spreadsheet is the most expensive option on this list.

16. An agentic AI build on your own data

What it is: A commission engine built on the data you already have, in your CRM, billing and payroll, using an LLM agent framework for plan configuration, crediting rules and dispute handling, with a governed calculation layer and audit trail underneath. This did not exist as a serious option two years ago. It does now, and the vendors know it: Salesforce published a

piece in August 2026 titled "Don't DIY Build Your Comp Management Tool with AI," and Performio argues generic LLMs "lack the necessary context."

Fits: Two very different customers. First, teams under 50 payees whose plans are simple and whose data already lives in one CRM, where a hosted build costs a fraction of a platform license. Second, large enterprises with unusual plan structures or data landscapes that no packaged product models well, who already have a data warehouse and an engineering team, and who are tired of paying an SI to customize a platform they do not control.

Pros: You own the logic and the data. No per-payee pricing. Plans change as fast as you can describe them. Integration is to your systems, not to a vendor's connector list.

Cons: Salesforce's critique is fair on the points that matter: "a prompt history is not a substitute for a governed system of record." A build has to be designed with SOX controls, version locks, an immutable calculation log and role-based access from day one, or Finance will reject it at the first audit. I have talked a client out of a build for exactly that reason: the controller would not sign off on a homegrown audit trail for ASC 606 capitalization, and he was right to refuse. It needs an owner after go-live. And it is a build, so the discipline is on you, not on a vendor's roadmap.

I have built a commission engine on a client's data warehouse, and I can tell you where it gets hard, because it is always the same place. Not the calculation. Retroactive adjustments. A crediting or hierarchy change effective three months back means re-running three closed periods, computing the delta against what was already paid, and explaining it on a statement. Every packaged engine in this list has an answer for that because their customers forced one out of them. A build has to design for it before the first line of code, and almost nobody does. If your build plan does not have the word "restatement" in it, it is not a plan yet.

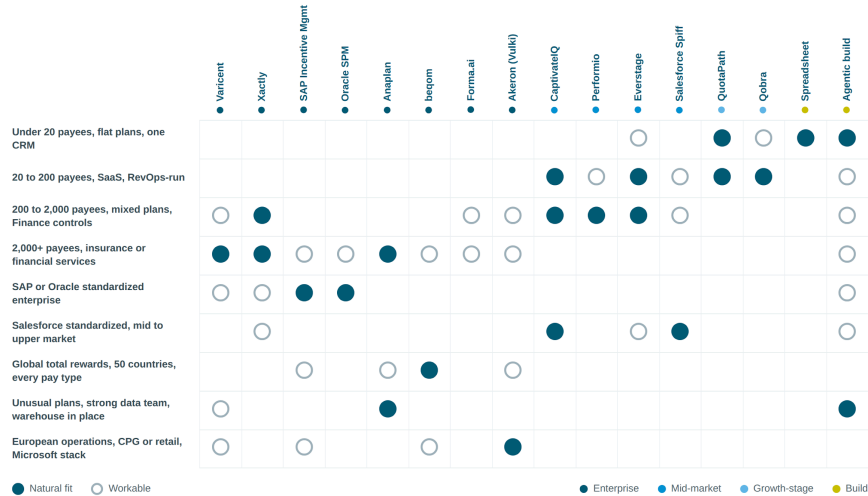
Lanshore also builds and hosts a version of this for teams under twenty reps, on the client's existing CRM, billing and payroll data, so read my enthusiasm for the build path with that disclosure in mind. The design rule we hold to there is the one I would give anyone: the LLM configures, explains and triages. It never calculates a payout and it never touches the ledger. A deterministic engine with a versioned log does that, and the agent sits on top of it.

Where I land: every major vendor is now shipping or previewing agents (Xactly's fleet, CaptivatelQ's beta, Everstage's Agent Core, Varicent's AI-native architecture, Akeron's Akyba, SAP Joule, Oracle's Coach). The question is no longer whether agents will do comp work. It is whether you rent them inside someone's platform or run them on your own data. For most mid-market companies the answer is still rent. For the two ends of the market it is increasingly build.

FIGURE 5

Sixteen options mapped to customer type

No ranking. A filled circle is a natural fit, an open circle is workable with trade-offs, blank means look elsewhere. Based on Lanshore implementation experience and the vendor positioning cited in the article.



Lanshore · Fit assessment, September 2026. Not a vendor ranking.

lanshore.com

Figure 5. Sixteen options mapped to customer type. Filled circle is a natural fit, open circle is workable, blank means look elsewhere.

The fit table

Customer type	Natural fits	Workable	Avoid
Under 20 payees, flat plans, one CRM	Spreadsheet, QuotaPath, agentic build	Qobra, Everstage	Any enterprise platform
20 to 200 payees, SaaS, RevOps-run	QuotaPath, Everstage, CaptivateIQ, Qobra	Performio, Spiff (if Salesforce), agentic build	Varicent, SAP, Oracle, Anaplan, beqom
200 to 2,000 payees, mixed plans, Finance controls	CaptivateIQ, Performio, Everstage, Xactly	Spiff, Forma.ai, Varicent, Akeron, agentic build	Spreadsheet
2,000-plus payees, insurance or financial services	Varicent, Xactly, Anaplan	SAP, Oracle, beqom, Forma.ai, agentic build	Growth-stage tools

SAP or Oracle standardized enterprise	SAP Incentive Management, Oracle SPM	Varicent, Xactly, agentic build	Tools with thin ERP connectors
Salesforce-standardize d, mid to upper market	Spiff, CaptivateIQ	Xactly, Everstage, agentic build	Spreadsheet
Global total rewards, 50 countries, every pay type	beqom	Anaplan, SAP, Akeron	Sales-comp-only tools
European operations, CPG or retail, Microsoft stack	Akeron	Varicent, beqom, SAP	US-only growth-stage tools
Unusual plans, strong data team, warehouse in place	Agentic build, Anaplan	Varicent	Rigid packaged tools

FIGURE 6

Buy, build, or stay in the spreadsheet

Three questions decide it. Answer them before you read a single vendor list.

QUESTION 1
How many payees, how many plans, how complex?

Under 20 payees, one or two flat plans
Spreadsheet is defensible for now

20 to 2,000 payees, tiers, splits, clawbacks
Buy a mid-market platform

2,000-plus payees, hierarchies, many variants
Buy an enterprise platform

QUESTION 2
Where does the data live and who owns it?

One CRM, no warehouse, no engineering
Buy, native to that CRM

SAP or Oracle ERP is the center of gravity
Shortlist the ERP vendor's ICM

Warehouse in place, data team, unusual plans
Agentic build is on the table

QUESTION 3
What does Finance need to sign off?

ASC 606 capitalization, SOX, per-contract audit trail
Spreadsheet is out

Multi-currency, multi-entity, 50 countries
Enterprise or total-rewards platform

Build must have version locks and an immutable calc log
Design controls in on day one

Spreadsheet
Zero license, infinite flexibility, and errors in 94 percent of audited operational spreadsheets (Panko). Fine until the first split, clawback or second currency.

Mid-market platform
Weeks to go-live, RevOps-administered, per-payee pricing. Watch the ASC 606 add-on and connector fees.

Enterprise platform
Handles anything, needs an SI, three to nine months by third-party estimates. Nobody publishes the timeline. Ask for it in writing.

Agentic build
You own the logic and data, no per-payee fee. "A prompt history is not a substitute for a governed system of record" (Salesforce). Build the governance first.

The tell: every major vendor now ships or previews agents. The question is not whether agents will do comp work. It is whether you rent them inside someone's platform or run them on your own data.

Lanshore · Sources: panko.shidler.hawaii.edu; salesforce.com/blog (Aug 2026); vendor pricing pages cited in the article

lanshore.com

Figure 6. Buy, build, or stay in the spreadsheet.

How to run the selection in six weeks

- Week 1.** Write the five-factor profile above for your company. One page. Get Finance and Sales to sign it.

2. **Week 2.** Shortlist three from the fit table. Not five. Three.
3. **Weeks 3 and 4.** Give each vendor your three ugliest real plans and a month of real transaction data. Score them on whether their team, not their salesperson, can configure them in a working session. Ask for the implementation timeline in writing.
4. **Week 5.** Reference calls with customers your size in your industry, found by you, not supplied by the vendor.
5. **Week 6.** Total cost over three years including implementation, escalators, connectors, ASC 606 add-ons and the internal admin headcount. Decide.

If a vendor's answer to the timeline question is "it depends," that is the answer.

The honest summary

Every list on page one of Google was written by a vendor, including in a sense this one. The difference is that I do not sell a platform, I make them work after the contract is signed, and I have watched every product above succeed and fail depending on who bought it and who was left to run it.

The star ratings measure ease of use for the people who write reviews, which skews toward mid-market SaaS admins. The analyst quadrants measure vision and execution in the abstract. Neither measures fit, and neither looks at the data model. Fit is the only thing that predicts whether your reps trust their statements in eighteen months, and the data model is the only thing that predicts whether you can still change a plan in year three.

One more thing from twenty five years of this. Own your plan specification outside the tool. Trilogy is gone. Callidus is three names deep inside SAP. Whatever you buy from this list will be acquired, renamed or retired before your plans are. Write the logic down where a controller can read it, and every one of these engines becomes a replaceable part.

If you are running a selection and want a second set of eyes on the shortlist, or you want to know whether your situation is one of the ones where a build beats a buy, Lanshore runs a two-week SPM fit assessment. We have implemented across nine platforms, so we will tell you which one we would not choose for you.

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